

Incident Post-Mortem Archive

Meridian Roasters Co. Document reference: MR-OPS-PM-ARCHIVE Maintained by:
Operations Coverage: 2024 — present Classification: Internal

How to read this archive

Every incident above severity 3 gets a post-mortem within ten working days. The format is fixed: summary, timeline, root cause, contributing factors, customer impact, what we did, and action items with an owner and a status.

Action item status is the most important field in this document. An open action item from eighteen months ago is not history, it is a live risk, and it is the reason most repeat incidents repeat.

Severity scale:

Severity	Meaning
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1	Single customer, contained, no systemic signal
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2	Multiple customers, one product or one route, resolved within a week
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3	Multiple customers across a product line, or any incident with a quality-specification deviation
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4	Material revenue or relationship risk, or a control failure
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5	Regulatory, safety, or existential
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INC-2024-03 — Carrier sortation failure, Pacific Northwest

Severity: 2 **Opened:** 11 March 2024 **Closed:** 22 March 2024 **Owner:** Fulfilment Operations

Summary

Approximately 90 parcels routed through a carrier sortation hub in Tacoma were held for six to nine days following a facility systems failure at the carrier. Customers in Washington and Oregon were affected.

Timeline

- **9 Mar** — Carrier facility systems failure, not notified to shippers
- **11 Mar** — First customer contacts received; tracking showing no movement
- **12 Mar** — Carrier confirms facility issue on escalation
- **14 Mar** — Affected parcel list assembled; proactive notification issued

- **18 Mar** — Parcels begin moving
- **22 Mar** — Last parcel delivered

Root cause

External. Carrier facility failure with no shipper notification.

Contributing factors

We learned of the problem from customers rather than from the carrier or from our own monitoring. Nothing in our systems watched for parcels whose tracking had stopped updating.

Customer impact

90 parcels, 71 customers. 38 tickets raised. Remedies issued under the third-party-attributable band, total USD 1,840.

Action items

#	Action	Owner	Status
1	Stalled-tracking alert where a parcel shows no scan for 72 hours	Fulfilment	Closed Jun 2024
2	Carrier notification SLA written into the next contract renewal	Procurement	Closed Nov 2024

Note

This incident is the reason we have stalled-tracking alerting at all. It worked as designed in February 2026.

INC-2024-11 — Belawan port closure and Nightwatch substitution

Severity: 4 **Opened:** 6 November 2024 **Closed:** 3 December 2024 **Owner:** Head of Quality

Summary

A port closure at Belawan delayed the Sumatran green coffee that forms the base of Nightwatch Blend by 23 days. With no Sumatran green in the silo and a scheduled roast, production substituted a Guatemalan lot into the base position of Nightwatch Blend across eleven roast batches between 12 and 27 November.

The substitute lot scored 81.2 against a Nightwatch base specification minimum of 82.0, a delta of 0.8 against specification — but the lot previously in use had scored 85.1, so the delta **as customers experienced it** was 3.9 points. The resulting cup was materially different: less body, more acidity, none of the earthy character Nightwatch drinkers buy it for.

No customer notification was issued. Quality complaints began arriving on 25 November, roughly two weeks after the first affected batches shipped, and continued into mid-December.

Timeline

- **14 Oct** — Belawan port closure begins
- **18 Oct** — Supplier notifies delay; relief claimed under force majeure
- **12 Nov** — First substituted roast batch produced. QA note recorded. Substitution authorised verbally by the roast lead
- **27 Nov** — Colombian-sourced Sumatran replacement arrives; substitution ends
- **25 Nov** — First quality complaint received
- **2 Dec** — Complaint volume recognised as a cluster rather than noise
- **3 Dec** — Root cause established by tracing complaints to batch records

Root cause

A blend base component was substituted with a materially lower-scoring lot, and customers were not told.

Contributing factors

Five, and all five are the reason this post-mortem matters.

No notification obligation existed. The QA manual at v2.2 did not require customer notification for any substitution. The decision to notify was discretionary and nobody made it.

Authority was inadequate. The substitution was authorised verbally by the roast lead. The manual at the time permitted this. A base-component substitution on a flagship blend was being decided by the person under the most schedule pressure.

Score delta was calculated against the wrong baseline. The team compared the substitute against the specification minimum (0.8, felt tolerable) rather than against the lot actually in use (3.9, obviously not tolerable). Customers do not taste the specification. They taste last month's bag.

The complaint cluster took seven days to recognise. Individual agents saw individual complaints. Nobody was looking at complaint rate by product against a baseline.

The connection to the port closure was never made until day 27. Procurement knew about the delay in October. Customer care saw complaints in late November. The two facts sat in different systems owned by different teams and nobody joined them, because no single role had reason to look at both.

Customer impact

Approximately 340 D2C customers and 2 wholesale accounts received affected product. 61 quality tickets. 14 subscription cancellations in the following eight weeks, against a baseline

of 3 to 5. One wholesale account, since retained, went to formal review of the supply relationship.

Remedy cost USD 4,120, issued under the then-current v3.1 caps with no attribution uplift available. Several customers were, in hindsight, under-remedied for what was a company-attributable failure — which is the finding that eventually produced §7.3 of the remedy policy.

What we did

Substitution ended when replacement green arrived. Affected customers were contacted retrospectively with an explanation and a credit. The wholesale account was visited in person.

Action items

#	Action	Owner	Status
1	Add a customer notification obligation for substitutions above a defined score delta, to the QA manual	Head of Quality	Closed Sep 2025 — issued as MR-QA-STD-002 v2.3 §5.4
2	Raise substitution authority for base components to Head of Quality, in writing	Head of Quality	Closed Sep 2025 — §5.2
3	Implement an automated customer notification trigger on any blend substitution exceeding 2.0 cupping points, firing at batch release rather than relying on a manual step	Engineering	OPEN — not implemented. Deferred Q1 2025, deferred again Q3 2025, carried into the 2026 plan. Currently unscheduled.
4	Complaint-rate monitoring by product against a rolling baseline, alerting on deviation	CX Analytics	OPEN — partially implemented. Reporting exists; alerting does not. A cluster is still recognised by a human noticing.
5	Negotiate a port-congestion carve-out from force majeure at the next Lintong renewal	Procurement	Closed Jul 2025 — MR-PROC-HB-003 §9.2
6	Sole-source review trigger lowered to two breaches	Procurement	Closed Sep 2024 — §11.1
7	Qualify a second source for every sole-sourced blend base component	Procurement	OPEN. Sumatran alternate qualified Mar 2025. Colombian alternate not qualified. Carried since Q3 2024.

Standing lesson

This incident had a supply cause, a quality consequence and a customer consequence, and each was visible to a different team. None of the three teams could see the whole shape of it. The delay was known twenty-seven days before the first complaint was understood.

The controls that would have caught it — an automated notification trigger and complaint-rate alerting — are action items 3 and 4, and **both remain open**.

INC-2025-04 — Decaf mislabelling

Severity: 3 **Opened:** 18 April 2025 **Closed:** 29 April 2025 **Owner:** Production

Summary

A packaging run applied Quietwater Decaf labels to approximately 200 bags of regular Cascadia Blend following a label reel change on the wrong line.

Root cause

Human error at line changeover, with no verification step between label load and run start.

Customer impact

47 customers received caffeinated coffee labelled as decaf. This is a consumer safety matter, not merely a quality one. All affected customers were contacted within 24 hours of discovery with an explicit instruction not to consume, and a full refund plus replacement was issued regardless of tier.

Action items

#	Action	Owner	Status
1	Barcode verification at label load, blocking run start on mismatch	Production	Closed Jul 2025
2	Decaf runs physically segregated to a dedicated line	Production	Closed Jun 2025

Note

The remedy here was issued without reference to caps, correctly. Safety overrides the remedy ladder. MR-CC-POL-004 §1 carries this forward.

INC-2025-09 — Subscription billing duplication

Severity: 3 **Opened:** 2 September 2025 **Closed:** 9 September 2025 **Owner:** Engineering

Summary

A retry loop in the subscription billing job double-charged 118 subscribers on the 1 September cycle.

Root cause

A payment gateway timeout was treated as a failure rather than an unknown, and the job retried a charge that had in fact succeeded.

Customer impact

118 customers. All duplicates refunded within 72 hours. 34 tickets. No cancellations attributable.

Action items

#	Action	Owner	Status
1	Idempotency keys on all charge operations	Engineering	Closed Sep 2025
2	Timeouts treated as indeterminate, requiring reconciliation before retry	Engineering	Closed Oct 2025

INC-2025-12 — Wholesale delivery window misses, Toronto

Severity: 2 **Opened:** 14 December 2025 **Closed:** 20 December 2025 **Owner:** Fulfilment Operations

Summary

Four consecutive wholesale deliveries to Toronto accounts arrived outside the agreed morning delivery window during the December peak, disrupting café opening preparation.

Root cause

Peak-season carrier capacity. Our wholesale deliveries were consolidated into a standard service rather than the committed window service, to manage cost.

Contributing factors

The decision to consolidate was taken in fulfilment without reference to the wholesale delivery commitments in the account agreements. Nobody checked what we had promised.

Customer impact

Three accounts, including Rosewood Coffee House, which raised it directly with its account manager and asked whether the committed window was contractual. It is.

Action items

#	Action	Owner	Status
1	Wholesale delivery commitments surfaced in the fulfilment planning view	Fulfilment	Closed Feb 2026
2	Peak-season capacity booked in advance for committed-window accounts	Fulfilment	OPEN. Scheduled for the 2026 peak planning cycle, not yet done.

Note

Rosewood Coffee House. Worth reading alongside anything else concerning that account, because this sits inside the rolling window that matters for relationship history.

Open action items, consolidated

Current as of the last archive review.

Ref	Action	Owner	Age
INC-2024-11 #3	Automated substitution notification trigger	Engineering	15 months
INC-2024-11 #4	Complaint-rate alerting by product	CX Analytics	15 months
INC-2024-11 #7	Colombian alternate source qualification	Procurement	15 months
INC-2025-12 #2	Peak capacity for committed-window accounts	Fulfilment	3 months

Four open items. Three of them come from the same incident, and all three of those concern the same failure shape: a supply interruption reaching a customer without anybody choosing to let it.